

Great Awakening

Grants, Prizes & Champions

A documentary photobook on American belief systems, New Age culture, and the line between staged and real imagery. Unpublished; expected 2027 from Loose Joints.

01 Open Calls

Ranked against one project, not in the abstract. The ordering weights three things in order: whether unpublished work, dummies or work-in-progress are accepted; whether the selector has a record with religion, belief, mysticism or American vernacular culture; and whether the prize is built for documentary or long-form photobooks rather than single images. Anything closing within 60 days is flagged whatever its rank.

BEST FIT

The strongest matches for an unpublished documentary photobook on American belief. Each takes work in progress, and none of them puts a claim on the book.

01 Guggenheim Fellowship

CLOSES IN 32 DAYS

John Simon Guggenheim Memorial Foundation · 2027 United States & Canada Competition

DEADLINE

15 September 2026

FEE

None

Work samples due 29 September 2026. Late applications are not accepted.

ELIGIBILITY

Citizens and permanent residents of the US and Canada. Photography is a standing category. Aimed at applicants with a substantial record of prior achievement; there is no requirement that the proposed work be finished or published.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

The cleanest hit on the top criterion. The fellowship funds work in progress and asks for no published outcome, so a book still a year from release is an asset rather than a disqualifier. The money is unrestricted and carries no publisher attached to it, which means it cannot collide with the Loose Joints contract the way a dummy prize might. Photography has been a named category for decades with a long line of American documentary fellows.

<https://www.gf.org/program/how-to-apply>

02 Alicia Patterson Fellowship

CLOSES IN 48 DAYS

Alicia Patterson Foundation, administered by the Fund for Investigative Journalism · 2027 cycle

DEADLINE

1 October 2026

FEE

None

Applications submitted through the FIJ portal since the December merger.

ELIGIBILITY

US-based print and online journalists, photojournalists explicitly included. Photographers submit one set of 8 to 12 samples, published or unpublished. Two applicants may collaborate on one proposal. Six-month fellowship pays \$20,000; twelve-month pays \$40,000.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Takes unpublished photographs on its face and funds the fieldwork rather than the artefact, which is the right shape for a book still being made. American belief systems sit squarely inside "subjects of public interest", and the fellowship rewards depth over output. Like the Guggenheim it makes no claim on publication rights, so it stacks with an existing book deal instead of competing with it.

<https://aliciapatterson.org/apply/>

03 Hasselblad Foundation Photo Book Grants

Hasselblad Foundation, Gothenburg · 2027 round

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

None

Next round opens early 2027. The 2026 round closed 1 April 2026 with decisions in June.

ELIGIBILITY

Open internationally to professionals working with photography — photographers, artists, curators, researchers and writers. Applications from individuals or groups. Two grants of SEK 100,000 each.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

The rare book award that pays out in production money rather than a publishing contract, which makes it one of the few that can co-fund a Loose Joints title instead of trying to replace it. Explicitly scoped to the development and publication of a photobook, so an unpublished manuscript is exactly what it is looking for. The international opening from 2025 removed the Nordic restriction that used to rule this out.

<https://www.hasselbladfoundation.org/en/stipend/photo-book-fellowships/>

OPEN NOW

Accepting entries as this issue goes out.

04 PhMuseum 2026 Women Photographers Grant**CLOSES IN 57 DAYS**

PhMuseum, Bologna

DEADLINE**10 October 2026****FEE**

€25 until 19 September, €30 until 10 October

Reduced entry fee until 19 September 2026.

ELIGIBILITY

Women and non-binary photographers worldwide. Ongoing and unpublished projects accepted. €10,000 in cash prizes assigned by an independent jury.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Accepts work-in-progress series, and PhMuseum juries reliably pick long-form documentary over single-image work. Confirm the eligibility definition applies to you before paying the fee — this is the only entry here with an identity-based restriction.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://phmuseum.com/grants/2026-women-photographers-grant>

05 Review Santa Fe

CENTER, Santa Fe · 25th edition, 24–26 October 2026

DEADLINE**Not yet announced****FEE**

Verify on the call page

The festival runs 24–26 October 2026. The next grants and awards cycle, including the Project Development Grant, is expected to close around 28 February 2027, matching the 2026 cycle.

ELIGIBILITY

The Project Development Grant funds a fine-art, reportage or documentary work-in-progress. Review Santa Fe itself is a juried portfolio review.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

The Project Development Grant is written for exactly this stage of a project. The more valuable half is the review itself: three days in front of US editors, curators and publishers is champion-building as much as it is grant-seeking, and it feeds Part 2 of this newsletter directly.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://centersantafe.org/callsforentry>

OPENING SOON — BOOK AND DUMMY AWARDS

Not open yet. Dates given are the expected cycle, anchored to the previous round. These are the core category for a book that does not exist in print yet.

06 Dummy Award 2027

The PhotoBookMuseum, Cologne · formerly the Kassel Dummy Award

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Verify on the call page

Expected to open late 2026 and close late January 2027. The 2026 round closed 31 January online, with physical dummies due in Cologne mid-February.

ELIGIBILITY

Any photographer, artist or designer worldwide. Unpublished photobook projects submitted as a physical dummy. Around 50 books are shortlisted and exhibited at international photography events; one project is published by MAS.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

The largest dummy award in the field and the purest hit on criteria one and three. The value here is not really the prize: a shortlisting puts the physical dummy in front of the photobook world a full year before the Loose Joints release, which is the best possible warm-up for the book. Note the winner's prize is publication — see the conflict note at the end of this section.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://dummyaward.org/>

07 LUMA Rencontres Dummy Book Award 2027

Les Rencontres d'Arles and LUMA Foundation

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Verify on the call page

Expected around May 2027. The 2026 round closed 13 May.

ELIGIBILITY

Open to any photographer or artist using photography submitting a previously unpublished dummy book. Special attention is paid to experimental and innovative forms of publishing. €25,000 production budget.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

The €25,000 is a production budget rather than a contract, and the jury explicitly rewards formal invention — directly relevant to a book whose subject is the seam between the staged and the real, where the sequencing and the object are doing argumentative work. Arles is also the single best European stage for a documentary photobook.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://www.rencontres-arles.com/>

08 Images Vevey Book Award 2027/28

Festival Images Vevey, Switzerland · 7th edition

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

None

Biennial. Expected to open January 2027. The 6th edition closed 25 February 2025.

ELIGIBILITY

Professional artists and photographers, and those in training, worldwide. No age limit, no regional restriction. Must be currently working on a book project. Award ranges from CHF 10,000 for co-publishing to CHF 20,000 where Images Vevey is the exclusive publisher.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

A grant to make an unpublished book, judged on how well the publication format answers the photographic content — which is the question this project has to solve anyway. The CHF 10,000 co-publishing tier is the one that can sit alongside a signed publisher; the CHF 20,000 exclusive tier cannot.

<https://www.images.ch/en/grand-prix/>

09 Aperture Portfolio Prize 2027

Aperture, New York

DEADLINE

11 January 2027

FEE

Free to enter; entrants must be current Aperture print subscribers

Call expected to open November 2026, following the 2026 pattern.

ELIGIBILITY

Worldwide. Unpublished and ongoing bodies of work.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Free, open to work in progress, and the institution on the other end is the one most worth knowing before a documentary photobook comes out. Aperture publishes, reviews and exhibits in this exact register; an entry is cheap and the relationship compounds. Budget for the subscription requirement now so it is not a blocker in January.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://aperture.org/calls-for-entry/portfolio-prize/>

10 APhF Dummy Award feat. Chose Commune

Athens Photo Festival · Athens Photo Festival 2027

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Verify on the call page

Expected late April 2027. The 2026 round closed 28 April online with physical copies postmarked by 30 April.

ELIGIBILITY

Juried competition open to unpublished photobook dummies worldwide. The winner receives a publishing contract with Chose Commune.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Straightforward on criteria one and three, and Chose Commune has real taste in this register. The prize is a contract, so the conflict note applies — worth entering for the shortlist exposure if your contract permits it.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://photofestival.gr/dummy-award/>

11 Landskrona Foto & Breadfield Dummy Award 2027

Landskrona Foto and Breadfield Press, Sweden

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Verify on the call page

Expected around April 2027. The 2026 round closed 30 April.

ELIGIBILITY

Unpublished book projects. The winner is published by Breadfield Press and Landskrona Foto.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

A smaller field than Cologne or Arles, which makes the odds better, and Breadfield makes serious documentary books. Prize is publication, so the conflict note applies.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://www.landskronafoto.org/>

12 Encontros da Imagem Photobook Award 2027

Encontros da Imagem, Braga, Portugal · includes a Best Dummy category

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Verify on the call page

Expected around May 2027. The 2026 round closed 25 May with physical books due 15 July.

ELIGIBILITY

International. Separate categories for published photobooks and for dummies, so an unpublished project enters the dummy strand.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Useful second-tier dummy award with a festival attached. Lower prestige than Cologne or Arles, but it runs a published-book category too — which means the same project can come back here after the Loose Joints release.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://encontrosdaimagem.com/>

13 PhMuseum 2027 Photography Grant

PhMuseum, Bologna · 15th edition

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Around €25–30, tiered by entry date

Expected to close around February 2027. The 2026 edition closed 19 February.

ELIGIBILITY

Open worldwide to ongoing and unpublished projects. €10,000 in cash prizes.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

The unrestricted sibling of the Women Photographers Grant above, with the same appetite for long-form documentary and no identity restriction. Modest money, but the shortlist gets real circulation in Europe.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://phmuseum.com/grants>

14 LensCulture Photobook Prize

LensCulture and Nazraeli Press · 2027 edition

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Verify on the call page

The inaugural 2026 edition closed 12 August 2026 — two days before this issue. Watch for the 2027 call.

ELIGIBILITY

An unpublished project. No dummy required: 20–30 images, a project statement and a short biography. The winning project is designed, printed and distributed by Nazraeli Press.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Listed because the entry requirement is unusually light — no dummy, just a sequence and a statement — which makes it the cheapest test of whether the edit reads to strangers. Missed by two days this year; diary the 2027 call. Prize is publication, so the conflict note applies.

<https://www.lensculture.com/photo-competitions/photobook>

NOT ELIGIBLE THIS CYCLE — CALENDAR IT

Real targets for this project, but not on this round. Listed so the timing decision gets made deliberately rather than by default.

15 Paris Photo–Aperture PhotoBook Awards

CLOSES IN 21 DAYS

NOT ELIGIBLE YET

Paris Photo and Aperture · 2026 edition

DEADLINE

4 September 2026

FEE

Tiered, with an early-bird rate that has already passed. Verify on the call page

Flagged because it closes inside 60 days, but the project is not eligible this cycle — entries must be finished, publicly available books.

ELIGIBILITY

Three categories: First PhotoBook, PhotoBook of the Year, Photography Catalog of the Year. Books must have been produced and published inside the edition's stated twelve-month window. First PhotoBook carries \$10,000.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Here as a calendar item, not an application. This is the prize that matters most for a documentary photobook, and First PhotoBook is a one-shot category — there is exactly one debut to spend. Fix the Loose Joints publication date against the eligibility window now, because a release that slips across the cut-off decides which edition you enter and you do not get to choose twice.

<https://aperture.org/calls-for-entry/photobook-awards/>

One conflict to check before entering anything

Several of the strongest dummy awards pay out in a publishing contract — Chose Commune at Athens, MAS at Cologne, Breadfield at Landskrona, Nazraeli at LensCulture. With a 2027 Loose Joints book already contracted, those prizes may be unenterable, or may need the publisher's sign-off, depending on the option and exclusivity clauses in your agreement. Read that clause once and the whole list resolves itself. The awards that carry cleanly alongside a signed publisher are the ones giving unrestricted or production money: the Guggenheim, Alicia Patterson, the Hasselblad book grants, the Images Vevey co-publishing tier, and the LUMA Rencontres production budget. Where a shortlisting rather than a win is the real prize, entering may still be worth it — but ask Loose Joints first, not after.

02 Champions

People who could credibly carry this book at release. A running list: names sent in a previous issue are not repeated unless something about their fit has changed. Contact routes given here are public and professional — institutional pages, departmental listings, public bylines.

SCHOLARS — AMERICAN RELIGION, VISUAL & MATERIAL CULTURE

Peter Manseau

Lilly Endowment Curator of American Religious History — Smithsonian National Museum of American History

The single closest match on the list. His book *The Apparitionists* (2017) is a full-length account of William Mumler, the Civil War spirit photographer who sold Mary Todd Lincoln a portrait of her husband's ghost — and it deliberately refuses to either endorse or debunk him. That is the exact fault line this project works: an image that is staged and sincere at once. He is also a curator, not only a writer, having built *Religion in Early America* at NMAH, so he can vouch for the book institutionally as well as in print.

CONTACT Staff page, americanhistory.si.edu

Rachel McBride Lindsey

Professor of American religious history and culture, Department of Theological Studies — Saint Louis University

A Communion of Shadows: Religion and Photography in Nineteenth-Century America (UNC Press, 2017) puts vernacular photography at the centre of American religious life — studio portraits tucked into Bibles, postmortem portraits with hair attached, spirit photographs, Holy Land stereographs. She reads ordinary photographs as devotional objects, which is the interpretive move this book needs someone respected to make in public. The book was built as a multimedia collaboration with MAVCOR at Yale, so she is already fluent in publishing images alongside argument.

CONTACT Faculty page, slu.edu

David Morgan

Professor of Religious Studies, with an appointment in Art, Art History and Visual Studies — Duke University

The field's anchor. *The Sacred Gaze* (2005) supplied the working vocabulary for how religious images do their work on viewers, and he co-edited *The Visual Culture of American Religions* (2001) with Sally Promey. A blurb or an essay from him places the book inside a scholarly conversation rather than leaving it as a picture book about odd Americans — which is the difference between a review cycle and a reading list.

CONTACT Faculty page, religioustudies.duke.edu

Sally M. Promey

Professor of Religion and Visual Culture; Professor of American Studies; Deputy Director, Institute of Sacred Music — Yale University

Directs MAVCOR, the Center for the Study of Material and Visual Cultures of Religion, which is the institutional home for exactly this material and publishes a journal that takes photographic essays seriously. Co-editor with Morgan of *The Visual Culture of American Religions*. MAVCOR is a plausible venue for a project feature timed to the release, which makes her useful twice over — as an endorser and as a publishing route.

CONTACT MAVCOR, mavcor.yale.edu

Courtney Bender

Professor of Religion — [Columbia University](#)

The New Metaphysicals: Spirituality and the American Religious Imagination (Chicago, 2010) is the standing ethnography of American New Age practice — and it is notable for treating its subjects without condescension, which is the tonal problem any photographer working this material has to solve. If the book is going to be read as serious rather than arch, she is one of the few people whose endorsement settles the question.

CONTACT [Department of Religion, columbia.edu](#)

Leigh Eric Schmidt

Edward C. Mallinckrodt University Professor — [Washington University in St. Louis](#)

Restless Souls: The Making of American Spirituality traces the long American line from Transcendentalism to the spiritual-but-not-religious present — the deep history underneath contemporary New Age culture. He also writes as an essayist and reviewer for general readers, so he is one of the few scholars here who might actually review the book somewhere outside the academy.

CONTACT [Faculty page, religiousstudies.wustl.edu](#)

D. W. Pasulka

Professor of Religious Studies — [University of North Carolina Wilmington](#)

American Cosmic: UFOs, Religion, Technology (Oxford, 2019) argues that media and images are replacing religious institutions as the authority that tells believers what is real — which is a one-sentence description of the problem this book is photographing. She reaches well past the academy, and her audience overlaps almost exactly with the readership a book on American belief wants to find.

CONTACT [Faculty page, uncw.edu](#)

CURATORS

Clément Chéroux

Joel and Anne Ehrenkranz Chief Curator of Photography — [The Museum of Modern Art, New York](#)

Curated *The Perfect Medium: Photography and the Occult* (2004), still the canonical exhibition on photography as an instrument of belief, and won the Grand Prix de l'Imaginaire for the book. He has since run photography at the Centre Pompidou and SFMOMA before MoMA, so he is both the most senior name on this list and the one with the most specific prior commitment to this subject. A long shot for a first approach, but the alignment is unusually exact and worth a considered letter rather than a mailing.

CONTACT [Department of Photography, moma.org](#)

Valérie Rousseau

Curatorial Chair for Exhibitions and Senior Curator of Self-Taught Art and Art Brut — [American Folk Art Museum, New York](#)

Has curated art brut photography exhibitions (2019 and 2021) and most recently *Self-Made: A Century of Inventing Artists*. Her subject is visionary and vernacular American making — the homemade cosmology, the private system worked out in a garage — which is the same cultural material this project photographs from the outside. The Folk Art Museum is also a realistic exhibition partner at a scale where a first approach can actually land.

CONTACT [folkartmuseum.org](#)

Gregory J. Harris

Donald and Marilyn Keough Family Curator of Photography — **High Museum of Art, Atlanta**

Co-curated *A Long Arc: Photography and the American South since 1845* with Sarah Kennel at VMFA — a survey that toured nationally with an Aperture catalogue. It is the recent benchmark for handling long-form American documentary as both an exhibition and a book, and the South is where a lot of American vernacular religion actually lives. He has demonstrated he can move a project from photographs to institution to publication, which is the arc this book needs.

CONTACT high.org

PHOTOBOOK CRITICS & EDITORS

David Levi Strauss

Critic and essayist; directed the graduate programme in Art Writing at the School of Visual Arts, 2007–21 — **Independent, New York**

Wrote *Photography and Belief* (David Zwirner Books, 2020), which sets out to explain why we believe photographs at all in an age when we know better — the precise theoretical question this project raises with pictures instead of argument. He holds ICP's Infinity Award for Writing and has been publishing on photography and politics since *Between the Eyes*. The most natural author for a catalogue essay or a long review.

CONTACT Published via David Zwirner Books and The Brooklyn Rail

Lesley A. Martin

Executive Director — **Printed Matter, Inc., New York**

Founded and published *The PhotoBook Review* for ten years, co-founded the Paris Photo–Aperture PhotoBook Awards, and edited more than 150 books across two decades at Aperture. There is not a more load-bearing person in American photobook publishing. Now at Printed Matter, which adds a distribution and event route on top of the editorial judgement.

CONTACT printedmatter.org

Brendan Embser

Senior editor, *Aperture* magazine — **Aperture, New York**

Edited *Aperture* monographs for Deana Lawson, Philip Montgomery, Louis Carlos Bernal, Ming Smith and Wendy Red Star — a list that shows a consistent appetite for American documentary with a metaphysical or communal charge to it. Formerly director of exhibitions at the Walther Collection, and a contributor to *The PhotoBook Review*. The realistic first point of contact at *Aperture*.

CONTACT Editorial contact via aperture.org

Sean O'Hagan

Photography critic — **The Guardian and The Observer**

The only dedicated photography critic among the *Guardian's* regular art writers, and the most consistent reviewer of photobooks in the mainstream UK press. For a *Loose Joints* title — a British publisher with a European distribution footprint — he is the single highest-leverage review in the anglophone press, and he has a long record of taking American documentary projects seriously rather than exotically.

CONTACT Public byline, theguardian.com

Next issue Monday. Open calls are re-checked every run; anything still live and still relevant is carried over rather than dropped, so nothing important falls off the desk between issues. Champions already sent are not repeated unless their fit has changed.